

Mamdani, Mahmood. *From Citizen to Refugee: Uganda Asians Come to Britain*, 2nd ed. Cape Town: Fahamu Press, 2011 [orig. 1973].

Mamdani was born into an ethnically Gujarati family in Bombay, in colonial India in 1946. He moved with his family to Kampala, Uganda, where he lived until Idi Amin's expulsion of Uganda's Asians in 1972. He worked as a scholar in Tanzania, Uganda, and South Africa before taking a position at Princeton University in the United States. He is currently a professor at Colombia University, and Director of the Makerere Institute in Uganda. In 2012, he visited Washington State University in Pullman to present on his research into the history of genocide and violence in East Africa. Excerpted and annotated by Jesse Spohnholz from pages 54–60.

Despite the physical harassment and even killings in the countryside, the exodus began with but a trickle. For the first month and a half the refugee flights to Britain went half-empty ... Those who tried to leave were systematically robbed by rank and file soldiers on the way to the airport. The Uganda government, realising that theft was perhaps *the* factor delaying the departure of many Asians, arranged for armed police to escort buses to the airport. With the high commission more cooperative, and the Ugandan government anxious to expedite the expulsion process, a larger stream of Asians began to leave.

During the last few weeks in Uganda, our thoughts wandered to Britain. What would it be like there? Every colonial child grew up with the notion that the motherland was the greenest pasture on earth, that the English tree had the sweetest fruit. In those last few weeks in Uganda there began a daily countdown on the television and radio. 'The British Asians should realise that they have only 14 days to leave for their homeland, Britain.' England now seemed far more imminent ...

The reports in the British press gave the impression of a public panic. To us it seemed as if the hysteria had been generated, at least in part, by the government itself. They seemed to be getting ready for us as one prepares for a swarm of locusts.

When the high commission rented another building to cope with the long queues and additional staff was brought over from England, they naturally called for people who had some experience in dealing with Uganda Asians. What this means in practice was that the reinforcement primarily consisted of immigration officials who had worked at London airports, keeping an eye on any Asians who might be trying to slip through the immigration net. Their view of the world was particularly conspiratorial. To them, as we had ample opportunities to witness, every affidavit was false, every statement was a lie and every Asian was an inscrutable oriental whose intentions had to be scrutinised most carefully.

In October, the *Daily Nation*, a Nairobi paper, sent a reporter to England to give an eyewitness account of the reception of the new immigrants. His report was hardly encouraging. He visited London and Leicester and wrote extensively of the graffiti on the tube station walls, on posters, on buildings, everywhere: 'wogs out.'¹ To top it all, the *Uganda Argus*² carried a series of advertisements from the city of Leicester. The message was clear: there are too many Asians already, so please go elsewhere. The advertisement, however, backfired. Most people by then had heard of England and of London. But now they knew there was some place called Leicesters, where there were numerous Asians. All those who had been undecided as to where to go, and there were many, after reading of the hostile reactions of the British public, started making arrangements to go to Leicester ...

¹ This is a racist slur used in Britain to refer to people who are non-white.

² At the time, this was the leading newspaper in Uganda.

The last week at home had been particularly difficult. Every night my parents and I went to sleep to the sound of gunfire. On Tuesday of the last week in October a nasty rumour had floated through Kampala that Amin had ordered the arbitrary arrest and death of over a hundred Asian families. Nobody stopped to question the truth of this, though we endlessly discussed the reasons behind it. To be prudent then meant to believe the worst, or so it seemed. The next day we left our home and separately out into safer parts of the city. I went to the University guesthouse. In a few days my parents left. The following day I went back home with a number of American and British friends. Would they please take whatever they wanted? Television, cushions, sheets, pots and pans, flowerpots, furniture, yes, everything. This had been a home with most of its contents having been accumulated over time. Now it had come down like a house of cards ... Before leaving the house I looked out from the balcony. In the distance I could see tiny mud huts, their tin roofs glistening under the hot tropical sun, each the home of family. I wondered what difference our expulsion would make to their future.

A few days later I left. My English and American friends came to Airways House to see me off. In those days, for an African to be seen with an Asian was to risk both lives. It was sufficient evidence of intended sabotage. Even two months earlier, when I had gone to see Maria, a friend at the university, she had pleaded, 'Please Mahmood, we can't go out together. Don't you know how things have changed? It's not me, it's the times. I'm sorry.'

As I boarded the bus for the airport and looked out of the window to wave goodbye, John made one last attempt to make light of the situation.

'Make sure this is the last time you are kicked out of a country on charges of being bourgeois!'

I tried hard to laugh. But it felt as if someone dear to me had died ... Once on the East African Airways plane I took my seat and tried to sleep, but sleep I could not ... I could see clearly in my mind my home, or rather the different houses we had lived in while my father moved up from petty clerk to a well-to-do auctioneer ... I could see the mosque around which we played as children, the primary school that we used to walk to early in the morning, carrying out lunch packages of chapatti³ and curried potatoes; the years in secondary school when, as a boy scout, I went climbing the mountains, swimming in ponds and lakes and learning to climb trees the way a monkey does; and the day I heard I was one of the 23 sponsored by the Uganda government for further studies in the United States ... there came a political awakening in the United States, the civil rights marches in the south and the Vietnam rallies. Tragedy, then, was always something that happened to other people. Finally ... I had come back home, home to my parents, home to friends and home to the land ... In the midst of people who had spent their lives in the country and who were about to lose everything they had ever had or known, it seemed selfish to feel sorry for myself.

But the 90 days had not been just a tragic event; they taught me a political lesson, a very simple lesson, but a lesson I would learn again in my next 90 days in Britain: unless you belong to the class that rules, a good argument will never be enough to safeguard your interests. Unless you are willing to sacrifice some of your immediate interests, and thus form a community with others, your future can never be secured.

The long journey had suddenly come to an end. The captain was announcing that the weather over London was 'overcast.'

³ Chapati (which Mamdani spelled with two ts) are a kind of flatbread commonly eaten in South Asia.

AN IMPORTANT ANNOUNCEMENT ON BEHALF OF THE COUNCIL OF THE CITY OF LEICESTER, ENGLAND

The City council of Leicester, England, believe that many families in Uganda are considering moving to Leicester.

If YOU are thinking of doing so, it is very important you should know that
**PRESENT CONDITIONS IN THE CITY ARE
VERY DIFFERENT FROM THOSE MET BY
EARLIER SETTLERS.** They are: —

HOUSING — several thousands of families are already on
the Council's waiting list

EDUCATION — hundreds of children are awaiting places in
the schools

SOCIAL AND HEALTH SERVICES — already stretched to
the limit

**IN YOUR OWN INTERESTS AND THOSE
OF YOUR FAMILY YOU SHOULD ACCEPT
THE ADVICE OF THE UGANDA
RESETTLEMENT BOARD AND NOT COME
TO LEICESTER**